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A ROOOST REPORT

The True Cost of Workforce Accommodation

What the nightly rate leaves out, and what it costs to put a crew up away from home for six months.



For procurement leads and the people who do the booking. Twelve pages, 35 cited sources, one worked example you can rerun with your own numbers.

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More work, further away, for fewer people willing to travel.

Nobody in the business owns the accommodation number, and the work is moving further from home. This page is about why that bill is about to grow.

Nobody owns the number. Ask a contractor what they spend on accommodation and you will usually get a pause, then a guess. The spend is real; it is just scattered. Some sits on project cost codes, some in expenses, some goes out as a nightly allowance, some lives on a company card in a drawer in the site office. Nobody adds it up because adding it up is nobody's job.

The work is moving. That was survivable when the work was local. It is not staying local. The government's infrastructure pipeline now lists 734 projects worth £718bn, and estimates the country will need between 629,000 and 706,000 construction workers every year for the next five years to deliver them.[1] The industry needs around 206,000 extra people by 2030 just to keep pace, about 41,200 a year.[2] One nuclear site alone expects 7,800 workers at peak, two-thirds of whom will need somewhere to live.[3]

So the crews will travel. So the crews will be travelling. In the US, where someone has measured it, construction is the most project-travel-intensive sector there is: a fifth of its business travel spend goes on trips of four nights or more, or trips that repeat.[4] That is a description of a crew on a job. This document is about what those trips cost once you count everything.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

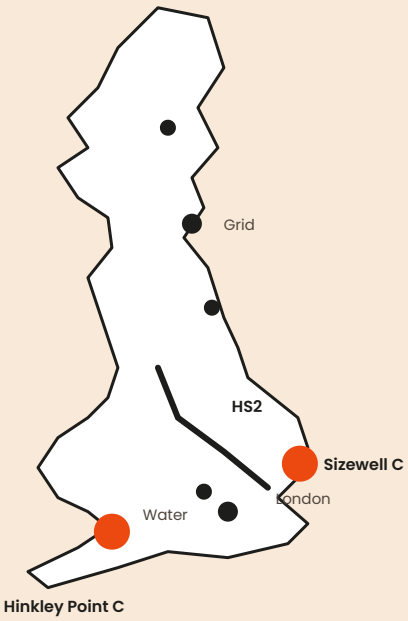
- Nobody in your business owns the accommodation number. That is normal, and it is the first thing to fix.
- The pipeline means more of your people working away, for longer.
- The rest of this document prices one crew: 20 people, 4 nights a week, 26 weeks, £60 a night.

£718bn
value of the UK infrastructure pipeline, across 734 projects [1]

629,000 to 706,000
construction workers needed every year for the next five years [1]

206,000
extra construction workers needed by 2030 [2]

7,800
peak workforce at Sizewell C, around two-thirds needing accommodation [3]



Where the pipeline is: nuclear in Suffolk and Somerset, the HS2 corridor, water and grid programmes.

HOW TO READ THIS DOCUMENT · THE STACK, PAGES 3 TO 10

3	The rate itself	£124,800
4	Platform commission inside it	£18,720
5	VAT you cannot reclaim	up to £20,800
6	The booker's hours	312 hours
7	Programme slip and early finish	£16,000 to £36,000
8	Distance and fatigue	unpriced
9	One skilled leaver	c. £30,000
10	The audit trail	none
11	**Added up**	£124,800 to £227,600

Every page adds one line to a running receipt at its foot. Page 11 prints the whole thing.

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The rate is the smallest number on the invoice.

The allowance, the hotel average and the surge rate are three different numbers. None of them is what a night costs once everything is counted.

The number in your head. Everyone in the industry carries a number in their head for a night's accommodation. The Working Rule Agreement sets the subsistence allowance at £53.69 a night from July 2026.[5] It is a tidy figure, and it bears little relation to what a room costs.

What a room costs. The average room in a regional UK hotel went for £93.10 a night in the first quarter of 2026. In London, £214.10.[6] Across the whole country in April it was £140.24.[7] None of those include parking for a van, breakfast at half five, or a kitchen, and all of them are averages: what a bed costs on a Tuesday in a town where nothing is happening.

When the town is busy. When something is happening, the rate does not wait politely for your crew. On the opening night of a stadium tour in Cardiff last summer, the average room hit £340.74, a record for the city. Edinburgh saw rates climb 92% for one concert weekend in 2024.[8] A crew on a 26-week job lives through every festival, conference and cup final that town hosts, and pays the surge each time, or moves.

What the rest of this is about. The question is not whether the sticker rate is fair. It is what else is stacked on top of it that never appears on the same line. The next seven pages are that stack.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

- The £53.69 allowance is a payroll figure, not a price. Budget on it and you are short before the job starts.
- A regional room averages £93.10; a busy weekend can triple it.
- The worked example uses £60 a night so no line that follows can be called loaded.

£53.69
nightly subsistence allowance, CIJC Working Rule Agreement, from 20 July 2026 [5]

£93.10
regional UK hotel average daily rate, Q1 2026 [6]

£340.74
Cardiff average room rate on one concert night, 2025 [8]



Three nightly rates to scale. The allowance is the mattress; everything beneath it is the stack this document prices. The surge rate runs off the page.

THIS PAGE ADDS — 20 PEOPLE · 4 NIGHTS A WEEK · 26 WEEKS · £60 A NIGHT

2,080 nights at £60 ..... **£124,800**

Running total — **Sticker £124,800**

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Roughly one night in seven is paying for the website.

Platform fees are priced into the nightly rate. On this crew that is £18,720 you never see itemised.

Who pays the platform. Most crew houses are found on the big listing platforms, and most of those platforms are paid by the host rather than the guest. Which sounds free. It isn't. The standard host-only fee on the largest short-let platform is 15.5% of the booking,[9] and any host who has been in business longer than a fortnight prices it into the nightly rate. Where the fee is split, the guest side runs from 14.1% to 16.5% on top of the price shown.[9] Hotel booking platforms work the same way, with commission commonly around 15% of room revenue.[10]

Why it matters at crew scale. None of this is a scandal. It is how listing platforms are paid, and for a family booking a week in Devon it is a fair trade for choice and a card machine. For a contractor placing 2,080 room nights on one project, it means roughly one night in every seven is paying for the search bar, before anyone has slept anywhere.

What it comes to. On our worked example, that is £18,720. It appears on no invoice as a separate line. It is simply the difference between what a room costs and what a room costs through a platform.

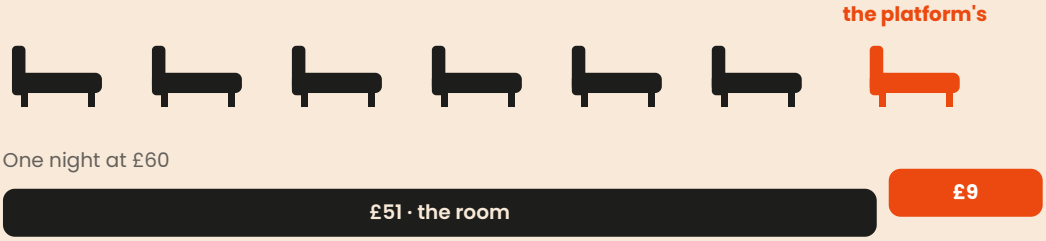
WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

- Around 15% of every platform-booked night pays for the platform, not the room.
- On 2,080 nights at £60, that is £18,720 inside the sticker price.
- It is avoidable only by booking direct, or through someone who does.

15.5%
standard host-only service fee on the largest short-let platform [9]

14.1% to 16.5%
guest-side fee where fees are split [9]

£18,720
commission embedded in 2,080 nights at £60



Seven nights booked through a platform: one of them pays for the website. Of each £60, about £9.

THIS PAGE ADDS — 20 PEOPLE · 4 NIGHTS A WEEK · 26 WEEKS · £60 A NIGHT

of which platform commission (not accommodation)	**£18,720**

ALREADY ON THE RECEIPT

2,080 nights at £60	£124,800
Running total	**Sticker £124,800 · commission sits inside it**

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Twenty percent. Sometimes recoverable. Mostly not.

VAT on crew accommodation is reclaimable in principle. In practice, how it is booked decides whether it comes back.

The rule. HMRC is clear that a business can reclaim the VAT on accommodation its employees need while working away from their normal workplace, and that includes block-booking rooms on one invoice.[11] Two conditions: the supplier has to be VAT registered, and you need a valid VAT invoice addressed to the business.[12]

The three routes. Now look at how crew accommodation is bought in practice. Route one: the lads get the allowance and sort themselves out. HMRC's guidance is blunt: "A business cannot claim VAT when a fixed allowance is paid to an employee even if tax invoices are held."[13] Route two: someone books a house on a platform. The receipt is a platform receipt in a card-holder's name, from a host who almost certainly isn't VAT registered; the typical UK host earns around £6,200 a year[14] against a registration threshold of £90,000.[15] No VAT charged, no VAT to reclaim, and no proper invoice for the audit file either. Route three: a hotel or a serviced supplier, invoiced to the company, with a VAT number on the paper. This one works, and it is the exception.

What it comes to. On a £124,800 spend, the VAT element where it is charged is £20,800. Whether that comes back is decided by who booked it and whose name is on the receipt.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

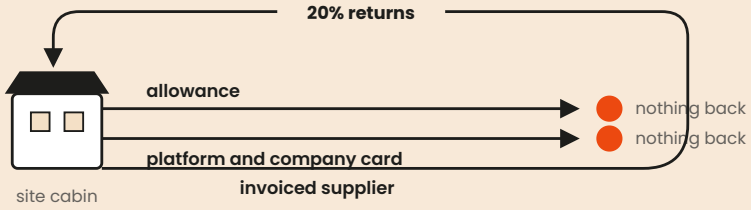
- The VAT on this spend is up to £20,800.
- It returns only on a VAT invoice in your company's name from a VAT-registered supplier.
- Allowances and platform receipts in a card-holder's name fail that test every time.

20%
standard UK VAT rate on accommodation

£90,000
VAT registration threshold since April 2024 [15]

£6,200
what a typical UK short-let host earns in a year [14]

£0
reclaimable VAT on spend paid out as a fixed allowance [13]



Booking ref.	A7K2-19
Card ending	4471
Nights	28
VAT No.	

Three ways to buy the same night. Two end with nothing back. The receipt on the right is the one finance usually gets.

THIS PAGE ADDS — 20 PEOPLE · 4 NIGHTS A WEEK · 26 WEEKS · £60 A NIGHT

VAT charged and not recovered ..... **up to £20,800**

ALREADY ON THE RECEIPT

2,080 nights at £60	£124,800
of which platform commission (not accommodation)	£18,720

Running total — **Sticker £124,800 · with likely lines £145,600**

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Somebody's whole job, buried inside another job.

Someone in your office is running a second job. Twelve hours a week of it, on this crew, for six months.

The part-time travel agent. Every contractor with a crew away has someone who has quietly become a part-time travel agent. Often an office manager or a project manager, sometimes a director's PA, occasionally the director. They are good at it. It was never what they were hired for.

Count the transactions. Count the transactions on our worked example. Five houses, booked in 28-night blocks over 26 weeks, is 30 bookings before a single thing changes. Things change. Add the extensions, the swap when two people can't share, the rebook when a host cancels, the "where am I staying tonight" texts at 9pm. Then hand finance the receipts. Processing an invoice manually costs an average of $9.84 and takes 8.2 days, and 18.4% of invoices come back with an exception[16] (a US benchmark, but the process is the same here). In this world an exception means the total doesn't match the nights or the name doesn't match the employee.

The hours. The bigger cost is the hours. Knowledge workers already spend 58% of their day on "work about work": coordinating, chasing, updating.[17] Accommodation is the purest form of it. Say the booking takes 12 hours a week (an assumption for this example, not a measured figure).[18] Over 26 weeks that is 312 hours, about eight working weeks of someone hired to run projects, not properties.

Why procurement misses it. This is the spend procurement rarely sees. Even companies with a managed travel programme report 32% of hotel nights booked outside it,[19] and only 4% of companies say they actively manage most of their tail spend.[20] Crew accommodation lives in that tail: too many small transactions to feel like a category, too much money to ignore.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

- 30 bookings before anything changes, then the extensions, swaps and rebooks.
- 12 hours a week for 26 weeks is 312 hours: eight working weeks of a project manager's time.
- Finance sees the receipts, not the hours. They appear on no report.

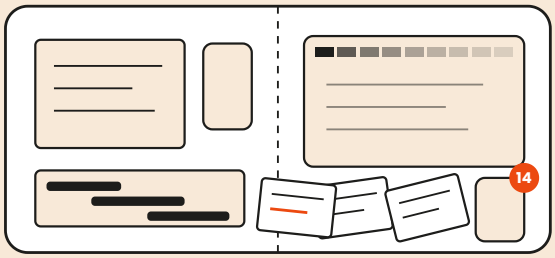
30+
separate bookings to house 20 people for six months in five houses, before anything changes

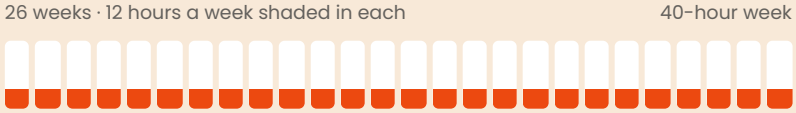
18.4%
average invoice exception rate [16]

58%
share of the working day spent on "work about work" [17]

32%
hotel bookings made outside the managed channel [19]

4%
companies actively managing most of their tail spend [20]





312 hours

Left: the job someone was hired for. Right: the one they inherited. Below: 12 hours a week, every week, for 26 weeks.

THIS PAGE ADDS — 20 PEOPLE · 4 NIGHTS A WEEK · 26 WEEKS · £60 A NIGHT

Booker's time, 12 hours a week for 26 weeks	**312 hours**

ALREADY ON THE RECEIPT

2,080 nights at £60	£124,800
of which platform commission (not accommodation)	£18,720
VAT charged and not recovered	up to £20,800

Running total — **Sticker £124,800 · with likely lines £145,600 · plus 312 hours**

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The job slips. The booking doesn't.

Programmes overrun and stop early. The booking does neither, and each direction costs you.

Programmes move. Programmes move. In a 2022 survey of UK construction professionals, 91% had worked on a project that ran late, and nearly half said delays had added more than 20% to costs.[21] A June 2026 study of 412 public sector projects found those procured at RIBA Stage 4 finished 12.84% over programme and 17.35% over cost.[22] Globally, large projects run about 20% longer than planned.[23]

The booking doesn't. Accommodation is booked to the programme you had, not the one you end up with. When the job runs long, the rate you negotiated in month one is gone by month seven and you are back in the market, possibly during the local festival. When the job stops early, you meet the long-stay cancellation terms. On the largest short-let platform, cancelling a stay of 28 nights or more after check-in means paying for every night used plus the next 30.[24] Five houses, 30 nights each, £240 a night per house: £36,000 of exposure for the sin of finishing early.

And when the crew grows. And when the crew doubles for six weeks of pours, someone is back on page 6, starting again.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

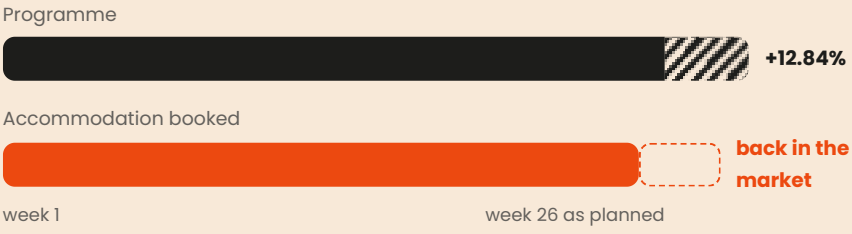
- Nine in ten projects run late; the average public-sector overrun is 12.84%.
- On this crew that is about 3.3 weeks of accommodation at whatever the market charges then: c. £16,000.
- Finish early and long-stay cancellation terms can cost 30 extra nights a house: up to £36,000.

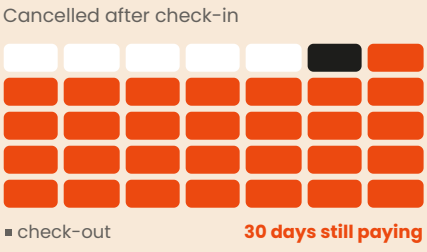
91%
construction professionals who have worked on a delayed project [21]

12.84%
average programme overrun on Stage 4 procured public projects, 2026 [22]

30 nights
additional liability when cancelling a long stay after check-in [24]

£36,000
cancellation exposure across five houses in the worked example





The programme stretches; the booking stops where the original programme did. Cancel after check-in and you pay 30 more nights.

THIS PAGE ADDS — 20 PEOPLE · 4 NIGHTS A WEEK · 26 WEEKS · £60 A NIGHT

3.3 weeks of overrun at the going rate ..... **c. £16,000 unbudgeted**

ALREADY ON THE RECEIPT

2,080 nights at £60	£124,800
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Booker's time, 12 hours a week for 26 weeks	312 hours

Running total — **Sticker £124,800 · likely £161,600 · possible £197,600 · plus 312 hours**

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Forty minutes further out is cheaper. Until it isn't.

A cheaper house forty minutes out adds eighty minutes a day to the crew's van time. The cost lands in the accident book, not the accommodation budget.

The cheapest bed. The cheapest bed near a site is rarely near the site. It is the house forty minutes away, and forty minutes each way is eighty minutes added to a ten-hour shift, in a van, in the dark, for six months.

What the regulators say. HSE puts the cost of fatigue at £115m to £240m a year in work accidents alone, and notes it is implicated in 20% of accidents on major roads.[25] RoSPA says fatigue may be a factor in up to a quarter of fatal and serious collisions.[26] The rail regulator's guidance to employers is specific: fatigue at the start of a shift rises with travel time, employers should control "door to door" time, and there should be an absolute maximum of 14 hours between leaving lodgings and returning to them.[27] One peer-reviewed study of 649 drivers found that driving 150km or more raised the odds of drifting out of lane 3.6 times.[28]

What it does to construction. Construction still accounts for the largest share of fatal injuries of any sector: 25 deaths last year, at a rate around five times the all-industry average.[29] One in five construction professionals surveyed in 2025 reported fatigue every day, one in four reported stress every day, and when asked what drives it, "lengthy commutes" and "time away from family" were on the list.[30]

Where the cost lands. None of this appears in the accommodation budget. It appears in the accident book, in the insurance premium, and in the mornings someone doesn't turn up.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

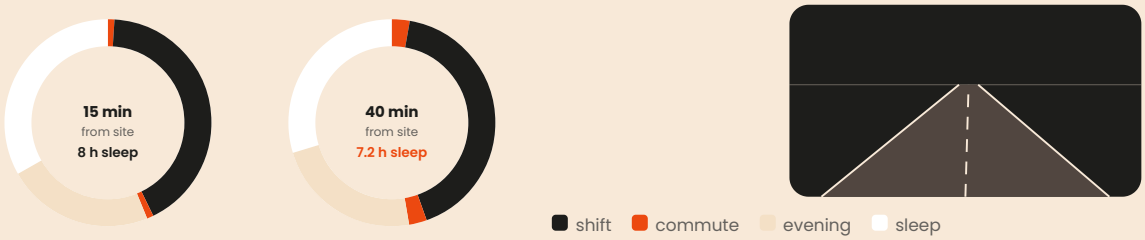
- Distance to site is a fatigue control, and fatigue is a measured cause of road and site incidents.
- The rail regulator's 14-hour door-to-door limit is a useful test for any crew house.
- This line is unpriced on the receipt. It is also the one that can stop a job.

£115m to £240m
HSE's estimate of what fatigue costs the UK in work accidents each year [25]

14 hours
maximum door-to-door day recommended by the rail regulator [27]

3.6x
increased odds of a lane-crossing when driving 150km or more [28]

20%
construction professionals reporting fatigue every day [30]



Same shift, same evening. The wedge that shrinks is sleep.

THIS PAGE ADDS

Fatigue, incidents, insurance ..... **not on this receipt, and the most expensive line on it**

20 PEOPLE · 4 NIGHTS A WEEK · 26 WEEKS · £60 A NIGHT

ALREADY ON THE RECEIPT

2,080 nights at £60	£124,800
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3.3 weeks of overrun at the going rate	c. £16,000 unbudgeted

Running total — **Sticker £124,800 · likely £161,600 · possible £197,600 · plus 312 hours · fatigue unpriced**

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Fewer people will travel for work. Where you put them decides who does.

Fewer people will work away from home. The ones who still do choose employers by where they are put up.

The pool is shrinking. The industry has always relied on people prepared to work away. That pool is shrinking. In 2015, 21% of construction workers had worked more than 100 miles from home in the previous year. By 2025 it was 10%.[31] The share working more than 50 miles away fell from 32% to 28% in three years.[31] CITB's own reading is that "the evidence suggests that model may become less effective in the years ahead", with "family, lifestyle and personal circumstances" now deciding where people will work.[31]

Vacancies are harder to fill. Meanwhile the vacancies get harder to fill. 45% of construction vacancies are skill-shortage vacancies, against 27% across all sectors.[32] 56% of UK employers say talent is harder to retain than a year ago, and 41% have seen new recruits leave inside 12 weeks.[33] Replacing one skilled employee was costed at £30,614 more than a decade ago, most of it lost output while the replacement gets up to speed.[34] And 82% of construction professionals surveyed in 2025 had thought about leaving the industry at least once in the past year.[30]

Accommodation is a retention tool. Put those together and accommodation stops being a cost line and becomes a retention tool. A crew put up in a clean house with their own rooms, a kitchen and somewhere secure for the vans comes back for the next job. A crew split across three budget hotels forty minutes apart starts asking about local work. Nobody writes that on a tender return. Everyone knows it.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

- The share of construction workers travelling 100+ miles has halved in ten years.
- Replacing one skilled leaver costs about £30,000 on a 2014 estimate.
- Decent accommodation is one of the few retention tools already in your budget.

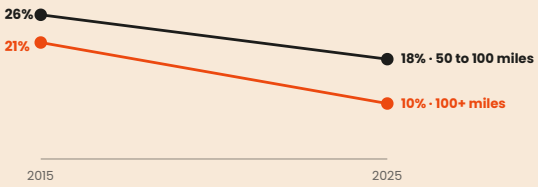
21% to 10%
construction workers who worked 100+ miles from home, 2015 against 2025 [31]

45% against 27%
skill-shortage vacancies in construction against all sectors [32]

41%
employers who have seen new recruits resign within 12 weeks [33]

£30,614
cost of replacing one employee, 2014 estimate [34]

Construction workers who worked away from home in the previous year [31]





Two published data points per line, nothing invented in between. The paragraph above draws on three survey years: 100+ miles, 21% (2015) to 10% (2025); 50 to 100 miles, 26% (2015) to 18% (2025); more than 50 miles, 32% (2022) to 28% (2025). All CITB, source 31.

THIS PAGE ADDS — 20 PEOPLE · 4 NIGHTS A WEEK · 26 WEEKS · £60 A NIGHT

One skilled leaver ..... **c. £30,000. Not a rounding error**

ALREADY ON THE RECEIPT

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Fatigue, incidents, insurance	not on this receipt, and the most expensive line on it

Running total — **Sticker £124,800 · likely £161,600 · possible £227,600 · plus 312 hours**

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Welfare used to be a paragraph. Now it's a weighting.

Welfare is now scored in tenders. If your accommodation lives in a spreadsheet and a card statement, you cannot show it.

The tender. The Procurement Act 2023 came into force on 24 February 2025. For central government contracts, the accompanying policy note makes social value a minimum 10% of the total score, and applying it has been mandatory since October 2025.[35] Anyone who has completed a Tier 1 pre-qualification lately knows how quickly those requirements flow down the chain. The question is no longer "do you have a welfare policy" but "show us".

The duty. Underneath it sits a duty that hasn't changed since 1974: an employer must ensure, so far as is reasonably practicable, "the health, safety and welfare at work of all his employees", including a working environment "adequate as regards facilities and arrangements for their welfare".[36] When your employee is 200 miles from home for six months, where they sleep is part of that environment.

The awkward part. Here is the awkward part. If the answer to "where is your crew staying" is a spreadsheet, a company card and a folder of platform receipts, you have no evidence. No record of what was vetted, how far it was from site, whether the smoke alarm worked, what the daily commute added to the project's carbon. You may have done everything right. You cannot show it.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

- Social value is at least 10% of the score on central government work, and flows down the supply chain.
- Where your crew sleeps is part of your welfare duty under the 1974 Act.
- Without a record of distance, checks and carbon, a good answer is still no evidence.

10%
minimum social value weighting in central government tenders [35]

24 Feb 2025
Procurement Act 2023 in force [35]

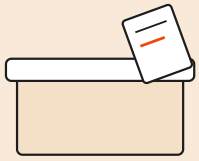
1974
the year employers' duty to their employees' welfare at work became law [36]

TENDER SCORECARD

Price		60%
Quality		30%
Social value		10%

Workforce welfare: show us


monthly reports


a shoebox of receipts

The 10% slice is where welfare is scored. Only one of these piles answers it.

THIS PAGE ADDS — 20 PEOPLE · 4 NIGHTS A WEEK · 26 WEEKS · £60 A NIGHT

Audit trail for welfare, distance and carbon ..... **none**

ALREADY ON THE RECEIPT

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Fatigue, incidents, insurance	not on this receipt, and the most expensive line on it
One skilled leaver	c. £30,000. Not a rounding error

Running total — **Sticker £124,800 · likely £161,600 · possible £227,600 · plus 312 hours**

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Same crew, same job, two receipts.

Everything from pages 3 to 10 applied to one crew. Sticker £124,800; with the likely lines £161,600; with the possible lines £227,600.

Here is the example in full. Twenty people, four nights a week, 26 weeks, a blended £60 a night. That is 2,080 nights and a sticker price of £124,800. The left-hand receipt is what most contractors think they spend. The right-hand one is closer to what they spend.

The figures on the right are not a forecast for your business. They are the cited benchmarks from the previous eight pages applied to one plausible crew. Swap in your own headcount, nights and rate and the shape holds. The point is that the sticker is the floor, not the total, and that four of the lines are decided by how the accommodation is bought rather than by what a room costs.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

ACCOMMODATION

2,080 nights at £60 ..... **£124,800**

TOTAL **£124,800**

decided by how you buy, not by what a room costs

Commission is shown for information; it sits inside the sticker price and is not added to the totals. The VAT line applies only where VAT was charged and the paperwork prevents recovery. "Likely" adds VAT and overrun; "possible" adds the cancellation exposure and one leaver. Overrun uses the 12.84% programme figure from [22]. Cancellation exposure is a maximum, not an expectation. Leaver cost uses the 2014 Oxford Economics figure [34], unadjusted for inflation, so if anything it is light.

WHAT IT IS — printed from the running tally, pages 3 to 10

ACCOMMODATION

2,080 nights at £60 ..... **£124,800**

of which platform commission, c. 15% **£18,720**
(inside the above)

VAT charged, not recovered ..... **up to £20,800**

Programme overrun, 3.3 weeks at the going rate ..... **c. £16,000**

Early-finish cancellation exposure, five houses ..... **up to £36,000**

Booker's time, 12 hrs a week ..... **312 hours**

One skilled leaver ..... **c. £30,000**

Fatigue, incidents, insurance ..... **unpriced**

Welfare, distance, carbon audit trail ..... **none**

STICKER **£124,800**

WITH THE LIKELY LINES **£161,600**

WITH THE POSSIBLE LINES **£227,600**

plus 312 hours
nobody ever invoiced

rooost

You don't need a new supplier to start. You need one number.

Before the next job away, sit the person who does the booking down with whoever signs the invoices and answer these together.

1 ☐ **What did accommodation cost on the last big job, all in?**

One number, every route, allowance included. If it takes more than a day to find, that is the first finding.

2 ☐ **Whose name is on the receipts, and is the VAT coming back?**

3 ☐ **How many hours a week does the booking take once the crew is in, and who covers it when that person is on leave?**

4 ☐ **What happened to the accommodation the last time the programme moved?**

Who untangled it, and what did it cost?

5 ☐ **If a client asked tomorrow where your crew is staying, how far it is from site and what it was checked for, could you show them?**

If the answers are comfortable, you are ahead of most of the industry. If they aren't, the numbers on page 11 are yours.

rooost

Rooost houses contractors' travelling crews near site for the length of the job. We source the property, including stock that never reaches the listing sites, agree terms that fit the programme, handle every change through the stay, and send finance one invoice per project, with the welfare, distance-to-site and carbon reporting the tender asks for. Your people get a proper house near site, their own rooms and somewhere for the vans, which is why crews come back for the next job. The person who books today stays in control; we carry the workload. One all-in nightly rate. No booking fee on top. We're paid by the properties we place you in. **rooost.co.uk**

rooost

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